

JIGS AND JOKES

Will Kemp (c. 1560–1603) was a founding member and also a sharer in the Lord Chamberlain's Men. He was a popular comic actor, and always danced a jig at the end of a play. Kemp had amazing energy, and, in 1600, he danced from London to Norwich, a distance of more than 100 miles (160 km). It took him nine days.



The Lord Chamberlain's Men

WHEN THE LONDON playhouses reopened in 1594, after their long closure due to the plague, Shakespeare joined a new company called the Lord Chamberlain's Men. He wrote about two plays a year for them and also worked as an actor. The company performed at the Theatre in north London, which was owned by James Burbage. His son Richard was the star actor, and Cuthbert, another of his sons, managed the business. Shakespeare was one of several "sharers" who invested money in the company to pay for costumes, playbooks, and the wages of actors and stage hands. In return, they took a share of the profits.



SLY SWORDSMAN

William Sly (died 1608) was, like Shakespeare, a player and sharer in the Lord Chamberlain's Men. He was a skilled swordsman, and often played the roles of fashionable gallants or fiery young men like Hotspur in *Henry IV Part One* and Tybalt in *Romeo and Juliet*.

Many costumes were made from scratch by members of the company

The stage hand sweeps up after a show at the Theatre



HIRED HELP

Among the company's hired men were several stage hands. Their job was to raise the playhouse flag, make sure that props were in the right place, fire the cannon, and clear up trash left behind by the audience. They were also responsible for operating special-effect devices, such as the crane used to lower actors playing angels or gods from the "heavens" above the stage.

Costumes and props were kept in baskets when not in use